AIRE™ Sample Facilitator Guide

Facilitator's Playbook for a Full-Day Intensive

A working day where a team takes a real AI and technology decision and has to govern it under pressure. People do not learn about the framework. They move through it, and they leave holding something they built.

Take note that this is intended as a sample.

A note before you run it

Most professional development asks people to sit still and receive. They get handed the right principles, the right policy language, the right slides, and then everyone is surprised when nothing changes on Monday. I have sat in those rooms. I have run better ones, and the difference was never the content. It was that people had to do something real, with stakes, and figure it out together.

So this is not a workshop. It is a day. A team walks in, gets put inside a real adoption decision, hits resistance on purpose, and has to keep making calls as the ground shifts under them. By the end they have built an actual governance kit for a real problem, and more importantly, they have practiced the kind of judgment the framework is built to grow.

There is a quiet structure underneath the day, and you will feel it even if you never name it to the room. The day is built as a problem worth solving, broken into smaller problems, so that capacity gets built by working through them rather than by being told the answers. There is an entrance that asks people to commit before they fully understand. There is a hard middle where the real learning happens. There is a still point where it consolidates. And there is a way back out that looks different than the way in, because the people walking it have changed. Run it that way and it sticks. Run it as a checklist and it will not.

One rule, said out loud at the start and returned to all day:

> **We work where we actually are, not where we wish we were.**

And one question on the wall that the whole day hangs on. Write it big before anyone arrives:

> **What if the way you adopt this tool matters more than the tool itself?**

You do not explain that question. You let the day answer it.

What a team leaves with

This is the promise. By the end of the day, each team holds a real **Governance Kit** for the challenge they worked, not a folder of notes:

1. A one-paragraph **Approach statement** (their stance and why)
2. An **approved-and-prohibited use** call for the tool in question
3. A working **decision checklist** anyone on staff could use tomorrow
4. A **30-day plan** with named owners and first steps
5. A **risk read** of what they almost got wrong

And every individual leaves with a personal one-pager: the one thing they will change in their own work.

The shape of the day

Full day, roughly six working hours plus breaks. It is modular. The half-day version runs Parts 1, 2, an abbreviated 3, and 6, and drops the showcase.

Part	What happens	Time
1	The Entrance — the provocation and the question	30 min
2	Read the terrain — the assessment as reconnaissance	45 min
3	The Sprint — the challenge, plus the injects	130 min
—	Lunch	45 min
4	The Center — the still point	30 min
5	The Showcase — teams present their build	75 min
6	The Return — carry it home	45 min
—	Breaks and buffer	40 min

The Sprint is the engine. The Center is the part everyone is tempted to cut and the part that makes the day matter. Protect both.

Teams and roles

Put people in mixed teams of four to six. Do not let the leaders cluster. Every team needs at least one person who actually uses the technology day to day, because the people closest to the work see what the people furthest from it cannot.

Inside each team, hand out **role cards**. People play a stake, not themselves, which frees them to argue honestly. The roles are in the appendix. The point is friction: a team where everyone agrees has not done the work yet.

A deeper note, for you, the facilitator

Read this part once and then trust it.

The day is built on a simple bet: people build durable capacity by struggling productively through a real problem, not by being handed a clean answer. So you are going to do a few things that feel counterintuitive.

You are going to let teams sit in difficulty longer than is comfortable. You are going to drop in complications right when a team thinks it has solved it. You are going to ask people to commit to a direction before they feel ready, and then make them revise. And you are going to build in deliberate pauses to reflect, because the learning does not happen during the doing, it happens in the moment just after, when people make sense of what they just did.

Your job is not to rescue. Your job is to design good difficulty and hold the space while people move through it. When a team is stuck and frustrated and close to a breakthrough, the worst thing you can do is give them the answer. The second worst is to let them give up. Stay in the middle of those two.

Part by part

For each part: the point, the time, what to do, and what I watch for.

Part 1 — The Entrance (30 min)

The point: Get people committed and a little off balance before they feel safe and analytical.

Do not open with an agenda. Open with a story or a scene with real stakes, something close enough to their world that it lands in the gut. Then put the challenge on the table and point at the question on the wall. Ask each person to write a private one-line answer to it. They do not share yet. They are now holding a stake in a question they cannot yet answer, which is exactly where you want them.

What I watch for: the urge to over-explain. The discomfort of not-knowing is the fuel for the whole day. Do not relieve it.

Part 2 — Read the terrain (45 min)

The point: Before anyone designs a solution, they have to see honestly where the ground actually is.

Run the GAP assessment, framed as reconnaissance. Individuals score the twelve cells alone, then teams calibrate fast: where do we disagree, and what does that tell us. Plot the team's read on the wall grid and name the cold spots out loud, using the gap names. The team now has a map of the terrain they are about to move across.

What I watch for: teams rushing to the solution. Slow them down. You cannot govern a thing you have not honestly looked at.

Part 3 — The Sprint (130 min)

The point: This is the work. Teams take the challenge and build the governance kit, while the ground keeps shifting.

Hand each team the **challenge brief** (sample in the appendix) with its constraints. They begin building. Then, on a clock, you drop the **injects**, the curveballs that force them to re-decide. Roughly one every twenty to twenty-five minutes. Each inject should make a team that felt finished realize it was not.

Structure their work with four moves they repeat at every turn: **observe** what is actually happening, **think** about what should govern it, **write** the call down, **land** on the one next step. Those four moves are the spine of how judgment gets built, so name them and hold to them.

What I watch for: the team that goes quiet and tidy. Quiet is usually avoidance. Walk over, drop the next inject, and watch them come back to life. Also watch for the loud member steamrolling the front-line voice. Protect that voice, it is usually right.

Part 4 — The Center (30 min)

The point: This is where the day converts from an activity into learning. Do not skip it. Do not shorten it.

Stop the sprint. Make it quiet. Individually, in silence, each person works the four moves on themselves, not the challenge: observe what just happened in your team, think about what it revealed, write down what you noticed about how you decide under pressure, land on one thing you want to carry. Then, and only then, a slow go-around where people share one sentence.

What I watch for: the room will resist the silence. Hold it anyway. The insight people leave with almost always forms in this pause, not in the sprint.

Part 5 — The Showcase (75 min)

The point: Make the work public, and let teams learn from how differently others moved through the same problem.

Each team presents its governance kit to the room and a small panel, using the rubric in the appendix. This is collaborative, not a competition. The panel and peers give two things to each team: one thing that is genuinely strong, and one question that would make it stronger. No scores read aloud, no winner. The range of approaches is the lesson.

What I watch for: feedback that performs cleverness instead of helping. Model the format yourself on the first team: one real strength, one honest question.

Part 6 — The Return (45 min)

The point: Carry it out of the room and into the actual organization, changed.

Now people come back to the question on the wall and answer it again, on paper, next to their first private answer from the morning. Most will have moved. Then each person writes their personal one-pager: the one thing they will change in their own work, the first step this week, and who will know if they did it. Teams set their thirty-day check-in on real calendars before anyone leaves.

What I watch for: commitments with no name and no date. Those are wishes. Send them back.

The Inject Deck

These are the curveballs that turn a worksheet into an experience. Print them on cards. Drop them during the Sprint, one every twenty to twenty-five minutes, reading the room for which one lands hardest next. Each one should force a real re-decision.

1. **The shadow tool.** You discover staff have already been using a different, unapproved tool for months. It works well. Now what.
2. **The data scare.** Someone realizes personal information has been going into the tool in ways no one agreed to. What do you do in the next hour, and what do you change for good.
3. **The reversal.** Your most senior sponsor just changed their mind and wants to pause everything. How do you respond without losing the room.
4. **The equity complaint.** A group you serve says this tool works worse for them than for everyone else. This is now the most important thing on the table.
5. **The budget cut.** Half your funding for this just disappeared. What survives, and what was never essential.
6. **The staff revolt.** The people who have to use this are quietly refusing. They are not wrong. What did you miss.
7. **The deadline.** Leadership moved the launch up by a month. What do you protect and what do you let go.
8. **The public misstep.** A peer organization just had a visible failure with the same tool. The whole sector is watching now.

Use four to six in a day. Always include the shadow tool and the equity complaint.

Role cards

Hand one to each team member. They argue the stake, not themselves.

- **The Sponsor.** You want this to work and you are accountable if it fails. You move fast and you do not love being slowed down. Your fear is wasting money and looking indecisive.
- **The Tech Lead.** You see the integration, the security, and the maintenance that no one else is thinking about. Your fear is being handed something you have to hold up alone forever.
- **The Equity Advocate.** You ask who this serves and who it leaves out, every time. Your fear is that the people with the least power will pay for a decision made too fast.
- **The Front-Line User.** You are the one who actually has to use this, all day. You know what will and will not work in the real conditions of the job. Your fear is being handed one more thing that does not fit how you work.
- **The Skeptic.** You have seen tools come and go. You ask whether this is worth it at all. Your fear is the team mistaking motion for progress.
- **The Newcomer** (optional, for larger teams). You are new and you ask the obvious questions no one else will. Your fear is that everyone is pretending to understand something they do not.

The Governance Kit template

What each team builds during the Sprint. Keep it to one page per piece.

1. **Approach statement.** One paragraph. Why we are adopting this, what values guide it, what responsible use looks like here. © 2026 Bytes with Don. AIRE™ and GAP™ are trademarks of Bytes with Don. All rights reserved.

2. **Approved and prohibited use.** Two or three things staff may clearly do, two or three they clearly may not.
3. **Decision checklist.** Five to seven yes-or-no questions a staff member runs before using the tool in a new situation.
4. **30-day plan.** The first three moves, each with an owner, a date, and a way to know it worked.
5. **Risk read.** The one thing we almost got wrong, and the inject that exposed it.

The Showcase rubric

Not for ranking. For focusing feedback. Each team is read on four things, and the panel names one strength and one sharpening question per team.

Dimension	The question behind it
Honesty	Did they look at the hard truth, or design around it?
Coherence	Does the stance actually drive the checklist and the plan?
Equity	Did they keep the least-powered people in the decision the whole way?
Usability	Could a real staff member actually use what they built tomorrow?

The reflection cadence

The four moves are the heartbeat of the day. Use them at every turn, not just in the Center.

- **Observe.** What is actually happening here, before judgment?
- **Think.** What should govern this?
- **Write.** What is our call, and why?
- **Land.** What is the one next step?

The morning question and the afternoon return are the bookends. People answer **"What if the way you adopt this tool matters more than the tool itself?"** privately at the start, and again at the end beside their first answer. The distance between those two answers is the day's real result.

Knowing if it worked

Run a short before-and-after, five statements rated 1 to 5 at the start and end of the day. Add two open prompts at the end: *what surprised you,* and *what will you do differently.* Across many sessions this becomes real evidence that the day changes something, which is what a district, a funder, or a conference wants to see. Run it again at the thirty-day check-in to see if it held.

#	Statement	Start	End
1	I know where we actually stand on AI and technology.	___	___
2	I can make a defensible adoption call under pressure.	___	___
3	I know how to keep the least-powered people in the decision.	___	___
4	I trust myself to govern a tool, not just use it.	___	___
5	I have a first step I will take this week.	___	___

Facilitator prep checklist

Two weeks out - [ ] Confirm mixed teams; make sure front-line users are in the room. - [ ] Choose or write the challenge brief so it is close to this group's real world. - [ ] Send the before-survey as pre-work.

Day of - [ ] The question is written large on the wall before anyone arrives. - [ ] Wall-sized grid, role cards, inject cards, governance kit handouts, commitment board, timer. - [ ] A small panel lined up for the showcase (internal leaders are fine).

Mindset - [ ] Design the difficulty. Hold the space. Do not rescue.

Appendix — A sample challenge brief

Swap in something close to your group's real world. This is the shape.

> **Your organization serves a community that depends on you. A new AI tool promises to save your staff hours every week. Leadership is enthusiastic. A pilot is already quietly running in one team, and it seems to be working. You have ninety days and a real budget, but not an unlimited one. Your job today is not to decide whether to use the tool. It is to decide how to adopt it responsibly, so that it serves the people you exist for and does not quietly harm them. Build the governance that makes that true.**

Constraints to set: a real population served, a real budget ceiling, a real deadline, and one thing that is already broken before you start.

Three lengths, same bones

Half day. Entrance, terrain, a tight single-inject sprint, and the return. No showcase. Good for a leadership team.

Full day. Everything here. The default.

Two-part series. A half-day sprint, then a build day two to three weeks later where teams bring real progress on their own organization's gaps. This is where it becomes a sustained change effort, not an event.

© 2026 Bytes with Don. AIRE™ and GAP™ are trademarks of Bytes with Don. All rights reserved.